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Cugoano, Condorcet, and Abolition on the Eve of Revolution

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Quobna Ottobah Cugoano's Thoughts and Sentiments on the Evil and Wicked Traffic of the Slavery and Commerce of the Human Species (1787), the first comprehensive antislavery treatise authored by a black writer in the West, was quickly published in an anonymous French translation, Réflexions sur la traite et l'esclavage des Nègres, Traduite de l'Anglais, d'OTTOBAH CUGOANO, afriquain, esclave à la Grenade et libre en Angleterre (Paris, 1788). Marshalling several forms of evidence—bibliographical, book-historical, biographical, and textual—this article argues that it seems highly probable that the French politician and abolitionist the Marquis de Condorcet was the principal agent in bringing Cugoano's jeremiad to the French reading public. Tendering the first scholarly assessment of the publication and reception of this translation, the essay situates the Réflexions in the contexts of Condorcet's own abolitionist writings and the work of the Société des amis de noirs, which he helped to found.

Introduction

Quobna Ottobah Cugoano's *Thoughts and Sentiments on the Evil and Wicked Traffic of the Slavery and Commerce of the Human Species, Humbly Submitted to the Inhabitants of Great-Britain*, among the most radical antislavery works published in the eighteenth century and the first comprehensive antislavery treatise authored by a black writer in the Western world, was originally published in London in 1787. An anonymous French translation with an extensive translator's preface was published the following year, under the title *Réflexions sur la traite et l'esclavage des Nègres, Traduite de l'Anglais, d'OTTOBAH CUGOANO, afriquain, esclave à la Grenade et libre en Angleterre*, by the printer and bookseller Jean-François Royez (1754?–1823).¹ We cannot be altogether

¹ *Reflections on the Trade and Enslavement of Blacks, Translated from the English of Ottobah Cugoano, African, a slave from Grenada and freed in England*. The imprint reads, “A Londres; Et se trouve à Paris, Chez Royez, Libraire, Quai des Augustins.” It should be noted that although *nègre* came to have derogatory connotations, both *noir* and *nègre* could be employed in a respectful sense in eighteenth-century France; here we will translate both as “black,” indicating the original French in brackets. Dictionaries of the period note that

certain who undertook the translation and printing of the *Réflexions*, but we believe there is a plausible case that Marie Jean Antoine Nicolas de Caritat, the Marquis de Condorcet (1743–94), may have been a primary agent in bringing Cugoano's powerful jeremiad against slavery to the people of France. Indeed, he may himself have been the translator, perhaps with the help of his wife, Sophie de Grouchy. We consider the implications, for understanding both Condorcet's thought and the French antislavery movement, of his possible role in this effort to make Cugoano's remarkable treatise quickly available to the French public at a moment when the abolitionist cause was among Condorcet's most cherished commitments.

The course of abolition in the French Empire was erratic and nonlinear. The most ardent French abolitionists arguably nurtured higher ambitions in 1788 than they would for the next several years. Soon the planter lobby would organize and persuade a majority of revolutionary legislators that the extraordinary importance of the Caribbean colonies to France's economy meant that abolition was impracticable.² France's major antislavery organization, the Société des amis des noirs, was launched in February of 1788 by the future Girondin leader Jacques Pierre Brissot de Warville, with a plan to transform French public opinion by publishing abolitionist texts, including translations of the latest works from Britain and America, "to procure for Blacks [*aux Noirs*] a greater number of readers, and therefore more partisans."³ Although the Société des amis des noirs's publishing effort was short-lived, because of the political crisis that soon erupted, a flurry of abolitionist publications became available to the public between February and May of 1788.⁴

The depredations of the Revolution leave the documentary record incomplete, but the Paris publication of Cugoano's spirited indictment in 1788 makes it clear that a powerful actor in France on the eve of the Revolution invested significantly to introduce the voice of a formerly enslaved African into this ferment of debate. What's

Nègre especially referred to West Africans enslaved in European colonies—see e.g. "Nègre," in Jean-François Féraud, *Dictionnaire critique de la langue française*, vol. 2 (E–N) (1787), in the ARTFL database, at <https://artflsrv04.uchicago.edu/philologic4.7/publicdicos>. Usage appears to have been shifting in just this period: in another manuscript, probably from the following year, Condorcet crossed out "nègres" and replaced it with "noirs." Marie Jean Antoine Nicolas de Caritat, the Marquis de Condorcet, "Variétés: Réflexions sur l'Esclavage des Nègres (Brouillon)" (9 Sept 1789?); Bibliothèque nationale, NAF 23639, f. 251r, at <https://archivesetmanuscrits.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cc121387>. The date is provided by the Inventaire Condorcet, at www.inventaire-condorcet.com/Inventory/Condorcet_manuscripts?ID=1218.

²Geggus writes that by January 1790 the Amis des noirs were "clearly on the defensive ... in the battle for public opinion." David Geggus, "Racial Equality, Slavery, and Colonial Secession during the Constituent Assembly," *American Historical Review* 94/5 (1989), 1290–1308, at 1295.

³Brissot, 4 March 1788, as recorded in the society's minutes, the *Registre de la Société instituée à Paris pour l'abolition de la traite des Nègres*, published in Marcel Dorigny and Bernard Gainot, *La société des amis des noirs 1788–1799: Contribution à l'histoire de l'abolition de l'esclavage* (Paris, 1998), 75–6. Henceforth we refer to an entry's date and to the page in Dorigny and Gainot. For a digitization of the manuscript see <https://mazarinum.bibliotheque-mazarine.fr/records/item/2489-registre-de-la-societe-instituee-a-paris-pour-l-abolition-de-la-traite-des-negres>; for an edited and digitized transcription see www.unicaen.fr/mazarine/san/index.html.

⁴On the society's publication strategy see Marie-Jeanne Rossignol, "Anthony Benezet's Antislavery Reputation in France," in Marie-Jeanne Rossignol and Bertrand van Ruymbeke, eds., *The Atlantic World of Anthony Benezet (1713–1784)* (Leiden, 2016), 164–84, esp. 180–83.

more, the Société des amis des noirs continued to champion this remarkable text amid the increasing unlikelihood of achieving abolition at a time of social, political, and economic instability. In Brissot's publication *Le patriote françois* in May 1790, the society des amis des noirs published their *Seconde Adresse à l'Assemblée Nationale*. In the face of strong headwinds, Petion and Brissot claim the right to argue their case in the public forum, the freedom to write against the crimes of the slave trade:

Legislators who have engraved the freedom to write in an immortal monument cannot command silence, especially from men of good will who write only to staunch tears and avert crimes. They cannot forbid us from proving that the trade and slavery are not only attacks on all rights but useless and fatal barbarities ... The sacred mission embraced by the Société [des amis des noirs] would have forbidden us any kind of alarm, even under despotism: what must it be under a free constitution?

Following their signatures as president and secretary is a list of twenty-five books on the slave trade published in French since 1788. This list can usefully be read as an affirmation of battle, a declaration of the freedom to publish, an assertion of the moral necessity of voicing the criminal nature of a traffic that debases the nation. Among the assembly of authors, the lone black voice is that of Cugoano.⁵

Condorcet was one of France's most prominent abolitionists when the *Réflexions* was published in 1788. An early member of the Société des amis des noirs and one of its most active, he was elected its president in December and was one of the small number of people for whom abolition remained a central cause throughout the revolution.⁶ In February 1789 he drafted a letter from the society to the local electors charged with sending deputies to the Estates General, urging them to instruct their deputies to pursue the abolition of both the trade and slavery, in the name of the "twenty nations and several million men" whose liberty and peace had been sacrificed to misconceived French interests.⁷ He published abolitionist articles in newspapers between 1790 and 1793, urging the Assembly, for instance, not to forget the slaves as they debated granting political equality to free men of color in the colonies.⁸

The clarity and vehemence of Condorcet's antislavery convictions may be traced back to the 1770s, when he first wrote extensively on the evils of slavery in his

⁵"Seconde Adresse à l'assemblée Nationale," *Le patriote françois: Journal libre, impartial et national par une société de citoyens*, Supplement au N° 272, 7 May 1790, 5–8, at 7: "Les législateurs qui ont gravé dans un monument immortels le droit de la liberté d'écrire, ne peuvent commander le silence, sur-tout à des hommes de bien qui n'écrivent que pour sécher des pleurs, que pour épargner des crimes. Ils ne peuvent nous défendre de prouver que la traite et l'esclavage ne sont pas seulement des attentats à tous les droits, mais d'inutiles et fatales barbaries ... La mission sainte, embrassée par la société, leur eût interdit toute espèce d'alarme, même sous le despotisme: que doit-ce être sous une constitution libre?"

⁶"Régistre," 2 Dec. 1788; Dorigny and Gainot, *La société des amis des noirs*, 186–7.

⁷Marie Jean Antoine Nicolas de Caritat, the Marquis de Condorcet, *Oeuvres complètes*, vol. 16 (Paris, 1804), 147–54, at 152: "Au corps electoral contre l'esclavage des noirs."

⁸*Chronique de Paris*, 25 March 1792, 337–8; see Yves Bénéot, "Condorcet journaliste et le combat anti-esclavagiste," in Pierre Crépel and Christian Gilain, eds., *Condorcet: Mathématicien, économiste, philosophe, homme politique* (Paris, 1989), 376–83.

“Remarques sur les Pensées de Pascal,” describing slavery as a public crime. It was a violation of natural right that could never be legitimated by positive law, and an offense against the most basic moral intuitions, tolerated only because racial prejudice “changes all our ideas.”⁹ His most extensive abolitionist work, *Réflexions sur l’esclavage des Nègres*, was first published in 1781 under the ostentatiously pseudonymous persona of “Monsieur Schwartz,” an evangelical Swiss pastor. It was republished with minor changes in 1788, though we find no evidence in those changes of an encounter with Cugoano’s ideas.¹⁰ (Both Condorcet texts are mentioned in the Cugoano translator’s preface, as we discuss below.) In the Schwartz *Réflexions*, Condorcet argued that immediate abolition was “the sole means of destroying slavery that conforms rigorously to the demands of justice.” But the work also proposed gradual abolition as a practical necessity, in part because the brutalization of slaves by the experience of enslavement made them temporarily incapable of exercising their natural rights: it would be dangerous to them and their fellow citizens if slaves were immediately freed and granted full legal rights.¹¹

Recent literature has been divided in its assessment of Condorcet’s abolitionism. Some scholars have stressed Condorcet’s uncompromising moral condemnation of slavery, a stance in keeping with his commitments to rights for women and religious minorities. For such scholars, the slow pace of abolition outlined in the Schwartz *Réflexions* represents a pragmatic concession to political realities.¹² Others have argued that Condorcet’s gradualism betrays deeper shortcomings, also apparent in the paternalist and Eurocentric vision of progress he outlined in his posthumous *Sketch for a Historical Survey of the Progress of the Human Mind* (*Esquisse d’un tableau historique des progrès de l’esprit humain*).¹³

⁹Condorcet wrote, “Tearing men from their country, by treachery and violence ... accustoming ourselves to make no difference between them and animals ... This is how we treat other men! It would be a horrible barbarity if these men were white; but they are black, and that changes all our ideas [Ce serait une horrible barbarie si ces hommes étaient blancs; mais ils sont noirs, et cela change toutes nos idées].” The passage appears in *Pensées de Pascal: Nouvelle édition, corrigée & augmentée* (A Londres [i.e. Deux-Ponts], 1776), 297–8, at <https://catalogue.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb31062704j>; as well as in Condorcet, *Oeuvres*, 12 vols. (1847–9), 3: 635–52, at 647; and a modern critical edition, *Éloge et Pensées de Pascal*, ed. Richard Parrish, vol. 80A of *Oeuvres complètes de Voltaire* (Oxford, 2008), 211–16. Also see Pierre Dockes, “Condorcet et l’esclavage des nègres ou esquisse d’une économie politique de l’esclavage à la veille de la Révolution française,” in Jean-Michel Servet, ed., *Idées économiques sous la Révolution* (Lyon, 1989), 85–123; and David Williams, *Condorcet and Modernity* (Cambridge, 2004), 140.

¹⁰[Condorcet], *Réflexions sur l’esclavage des nègres*. Par M. Schwartz, pasteur du Saint-Évangile à Bienne, membre de la Société économique de B***. Nouvelle édition revue & corrigée. A Neuchâtel; et se trouve à Paris, chez Froullé, libraire, quai des Augustins, au coin de la rue Pavée. M. DCC. LXXXVIII (1781, 2nd edn 1788), i. The primary change is the addition of a “post-scriptum” about developments in the United States and the formation of antislavery societies in England and France.

¹¹[Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), Ch. 9, 33: “le seul moyen de détruire l’esclavage, qui soit rigoureusement conforme à la justice.”

¹²Richard Popkin, “Condorcet: Abolitionist,” *Condorcet Studies* 1 (1984), 35–47; Elisabeth Badinter and Robert Badinter, *Condorcet: Un intellectuel en politique* (Paris, 1988); Williams, *Condorcet and Modernity*.

¹³Joseph Jurt, “L’idée de progrès et l’opposition à l’esclavage,” in Crépel and Gilain, *Condorcet: Mathématicien*, 385–95.

Laurent Dubois describes the argument that slavery's brutality had rendered its victims unfit for immediate emancipation as a form of "Republican racism," in which "an abolitionist version of the history of slavery became a vehicle for justifying continued racial exclusion."¹⁴ Condorcet's "authoritarian social epistemology," Elizabeth Anderson has argued, meant that he was incapable of imagining that the enslaved might have something to teach Europeans about justice.¹⁵ Anderson, Dubois, and other critics are right to point to the troubling inconsistencies of the gradualist program in Condorcet's *Réflexions*, particularly its willingness to consign the enslaved, during the transitional period, to the control and guidance of the white planters whom Condorcet condemned as morally depraved criminals.

Yet if Condorcet was indeed the primary agent responsible for publishing a translation of Cugoano's book, as the work's bookseller Royez claimed on several occasions, his abolitionism and his social epistemology appear in a new light. Cugoano called for the immediate abolition of slavery, flatly rejected the idea of indemnifying slaveholders, and entertained the idea of enslaving the enslavers as a form of punishment and restitution. Condorcet's efforts to make Cugoano's treatise available to the French public would indicate his eagerness to circulate ideas more radical than he was willing to avow under his own name.¹⁶ They suggest his interest in placing such arguments, by a formerly enslaved African author who wrote from a particular position of moral authority, before the French public.

The publication of the translation tells us that Condorcet, or someone like him with the means and ability to do so, undertook to insert Cugoano's testimony and beliefs into the rapidly changing arena of contestation over slavery in the French Empire. This was a world of argument about principle and policy of the highest possible stakes: one that was rapidly shifting, in part because of the astonishing transformations in France's trade in African captives and in its plantation colonies during the 1780s. After the American Revolutionary War ended in 1783, the number of enslaved Africans disembarked in Saint-Domingue, France's largest Antillean colony, rose from a prewar average of 10,000 per year to more than 24,000 in 1784. From 1784 to 1790, more than 220,000 enslaved Africans arrived in Saint-Domingue, nearly 40 percent of the transatlantic slave trade during that period.¹⁷

French planters, including increasing numbers of absentee investors, "poured capital into the colony," and they fiercely resisted the state's modest efforts to rein in

¹⁴Laurent Dubois, *A Colony of Citizens: Revolution and Slave Emancipation in the French Caribbean, 1787–1804* (Chapel Hill, 2004), 177–82, esp. 182.

¹⁵Elizabeth Anderson, "The Social Epistemology of Morality," in Michael S. Brady and Miranda Fricker, eds., *The Epistemic Life of Groups: Essays in the Epistemology of Collectives* (Oxford, 2016), 75–94, at 83–4.

¹⁶The Schwartz work was publicly acknowledged as Condorcet's during his lifetime. See e.g. the list of antislavery works promulgated by the Société des amis des noirs, where it appears as "Réflexions sur l'esclavage des nègres, par le Pasteur Schwartz (M. de Condorcet)." *Le patriote français*, 7 May 1790, 8.

¹⁷David Geggus, "Saint-Domingue on the Eve of the Haitian Revolution," in David Patrick Geggus and Norman Fiering, eds., *The World of the Haitian Revolution* (Bloomington, 2009), 7; and see Geggus, "The French Slave Trade: An Overview," *WMQ* 3rd ser., 58 (2001), 139–70.

abuses that might provoke slave revolts.¹⁸ The planters' savagery in search of short-term profits was such that on average Africans died within eight years of their arrival.¹⁹ After the American War, as Bernard Gainot has emphasized, "colonial affairs were no longer the preserve of the closed world of Versailles offices," but "were scrutinized in public debate, which was fueled by a wave of memorandums and pamphlets, the establishment of *sociétés de pensée*, and an incipient independent press."²⁰ Accordingly, the lack of a black voice in the debates was a glaring omission, one that was remedied by introducing Cugoano's attack on the system of transatlantic slavery into the fray.

Cugoano's *Réflexions* as an intervention in French antislavery debates

Nothing like Cugoano's text had existed before.²¹ Cugoano was the first formerly enslaved sub-Saharan African to add to the story of his captivity an extensive, fully fledged indictment in a European language of the system and the culture that had enslaved him. Unlike other books by African authors in the eighteenth century, *Thoughts and Sentiments* is not an autobiography. After a brief account of Cugoano's enslavement and emancipation, the book elaborates arguments against racism and slavery on the basis of Scripture, natural law, and English law, presenting a program of immediate abolition, national repentance, and restitution for the evils of slavery. Perhaps the most radical feature of Cugoano's argument in its political context was his demand for immediate abolition. He called for the "total abolition, and an universal emancipation of slaves, and the enfranchisement of all the Black People employed in the culture of the Colonies, taking place as it ought to do, and without any hesitation,

¹⁸John Garrigus, "Saint-Domingue on the Eve of the Revolution," in Wim Klooster, ed., *The Cambridge History of the Age of Atlantic Revolutions*, vol. 2 (Cambridge, 2023), 588–613, at 589.

¹⁹Trevor Burnard and John Garrigus, *The Plantation Machine: Atlantic Capitalism in French Saint-Domingue and British Jamaica* (Philadelphia, 2016), 251–3. The authors draw statistics from the Saint-Domingue planter Marc-Antoine Avasse's *Tableau comparatif des productions des colonies françaises aux Antilles, avec celles des colonies anglaises, espagnoles et hollandaises de l'année 1787 à 1788* (Paris, [1799]), Tables 8 and 9.

²⁰Bernard Gainot, "The Haitian Revolutions," in Wim Klooster, ed., *The Cambridge History of the Age of Atlantic Revolutions*, vol. 2 (Cambridge, 2023), 614–36, at 615.

²¹Vincent Carretta, editor of the modern English edition, calls Cugoano "the first English-speaking African historian of slavery and the slave trade, and the first African to criticize European imperialism in the Americas" and characterizes Cugoano's *Thoughts and Sentiments* as "[b]y far the most radical assault on slavery as well as the slave trade by a writer of African descent." Vincent Carretta, "Introduction," in Quobna Ottobah Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, ed. Vincent Carretta (New York, 1999), xx–xxi. On Cugoano's English original also see Henry Paget, "Between Hume and Cugoano: Race, Ethnicity and Philosophical Entrapment," *Journal of Speculative Philosophy* 18/2 (2004), 129–48; Stefan M. Wheelock, *Barbaric Culture and Black Critique* (Charlottesville, 2015); Adam Dahl, "Oppression and Racial Slavery: Abolitionist Challenges to Neo-republicanism," *Contemporary Political Theory* 20/2 (2020), 272–95; Carrie D. Shanafelt, "A World of Debt': Quobna Ottobah Cugoano, *The Wealth of Nations*, and the End of Finance," *Eighteenth-Century Studies* 55/1 (2021), 21–43; Sankar Muthu, "A Cosmopolitanism of Countervailing Powers: Global Domination in the Political Thought of Immanuel Kant and Quobna Ottobah Cugoano," in Joan-Pau Rubiés and Neil Safier, eds., *Cosmopolitanism and the Enlightenment* (Cambridge, 2023), 239–62.

or delay for a moment, even though it might have some seeming appearance of loss either to government or to individuals.”²²

Cugoano offered his plan for immediate abolition in the context of an argument that the British nation, collectively guilty of the crime of slavery, must undertake a comprehensive reparation of relations with the enslaved people of the British colonies and the political entities of Africa that had been devastated by the triangular trade. While insisting that the evil of slavery was irreparable, he wrote movingly of the need to make “a just commutation for what cannot be fully restored, in order to make restoration, as far as could be, for the injuries already done.” He called on the nation to carry out a collective reckoning with its participation in the crime of slavery: a “universal reformation and national repentance.”²³ This national awakening should lead the British to transform not only their plantation colonies, but also their entire international policy.

Cugoano’s remarkable text seems to have disappeared almost without a trace in Britain after its publication. Other than the publisher’s prospectus, not a single advertisement or book notice is known to exist, and no contemporary review made its way into print. The book made no appearance whatever in the public press.²⁴ It appears that Cugoano’s thoroughgoing attack on slavery, on the commercial trade that had enslaved him, and on the king, parliament, and culture that countenanced such moral enormities was too radical for the taste of the main English abolitionist group, the Society for Effecting the Abolition of the Slave Trade (London). They chose neither to champion the volume, nor even so much as to mention it in any of their many publications.²⁵ Cugoano’s call for the immediate abolition of slavery—and not merely the slave trade—ran counter to the committee’s carefully calibrated strategy of winning the middle in Parliament by not being too extreme. His book’s fate was very different from the small number of earlier publications by formerly enslaved African authors,

²²Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, ed. Caretta, 91–2; we cite this edition unless otherwise noted. Even Cugoano’s plan had a gradualist element: although all slaveholders would be required immediately to “mitigate the labour of their slaves to that of a lawful servitude” and provide religious instruction, only those who had been enslaved at least seven years and could show some knowledge of Christianity would be free and entitled either to leave their former slaveholders or to remain with “reasonable wages and maintenance.” The others would be freed when they reached the seven-year mark. On the relation between the autobiographical and the philosophical in Cugoano’s text see Pierre Saint-Amand, “Silence de réparation: Les traductions en français d’Ottobah Cugoano et d’Olaudah Equiano,” *L’esprit créateur* 64/4 (2024), 143–58.

²³*Ibid.*, 102, 97; and see Stephen Best and Saidiya Hartman, “Fugitive Justice,” *Representations* 92/1 (2005), 1–15, at 1, who write that Cugoano’s call for restitution “embrac[ed] the limited scope of the possible in face of the irreparable.”

²⁴See Michael F. Suarez, S.J., “Feeding the Machine: A Triple System of Networks,” Printing Abolition, the A. S. W. Rosenbach Lectures in Bibliography, University of Pennsylvania, Lecture 1, at www.youtube.com/watch?v=axBzUB95wR4, at 47:30 et seq. In 1791, Cugoano self-published an abridged text of his *Thoughts and Sentiments*. This “abstract,” consisting of less than one-fourth of the original, was published by subscription, but only attracted 165 subscribers (title page); the list is reprinted in Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, ed. Caretta, 147–50.

²⁵Cugoano is also not mentioned in the minutes of the London Society for Effecting the Abolition of the Slave Trade, 1787–1819 (BL Add. MSS 21254, 21255, 21256).

far more politically moderate, that had been published with the support of British philanthropists and with considerable public success.²⁶

Given how little uptake it seems to have had in England, it is striking that Cugoano's book was quickly translated into French. Whoever chose to undertake this translation made a significant cultural and material investment in it. It was printed in two formats, a compact duodecimo printed on ordinary paper, and an octavo printed on fine paper (*beau papier*), in which the text is surrounded by unusually wide margins.²⁷ Most probably, the more workaday and less expensive duodecimo was aimed for sale to a broader audience of common readers, while the octavo was a deluxe issue intended for distribution to political elites and other public dignitaries. Printing on large, high-quality paper, though more costly, would have accorded the publication greater dignity and importance, and thus more attention.²⁸ A copy was almost certainly sent to the king by those responsible for publishing the French translation, as evidenced by the fine-paper copy bound in red morocco, bearing in gold the royal arms and cipher of Louis XVI and originally housed in the Bibliothèque royale, as demonstrated by the many stamps added to the text block documenting its provenance. In the Schwartz *Réflexions*, Condorcet had argued that the "revolution" needed to bring about the abolition of slavery would require convincing both the sovereign and public opinion.²⁹ Notably, then, the dual printing strategy of the French edition of Cugoano's text—in a cheaper edition for widespread distribution and an elite edition, including a copy sent to the king—realized a project that Condorcet had previously outlined.

²⁶James Albert Ukawsaw Gronniosaw, *A Narrative of the Most Remarkable Particulars in the Life of James Albert Ukawsaw Gronniosaw, An African ...* (Bath, 1774) was by the end of the century published in at least ten editions in England and America, translated into Welsh, and serialized in a prominent New York magazine. See Vincent Carretta, "Gronniosaw, Ukawsaw," *Oxford DNB* (23 Sept. 2004), at www.oxforddnb.com/view/10.1093/ref:odnb/9780198614128.001.0001/odnb-9780198614128-e-71634 (accessed 19 July 2024). Ignatius Sancho's posthumously published *Letters of the Late Ignatius Sancho, An African* (London, 1782) had a subscription list of more than 1,200 individuals and earned Sancho's widow more than £500 in addition to an undisclosed sum paid by the booksellers for the right to publish a second edition. See Vincent Carretta, "Sancho, (Charles) Ignatius (1729?–1780), author," *Oxford DNB* (11 Feb. 2021), at www.oxforddnb.com/view/10.1093/ref:odnb/9780198614128.001.0001/odnb-9780198614128-e-24609 (accessed 19 July 2024). Similarly, *A Narrative of the Lord's Wonderful Dealings with John Marrant a Black, Born in New-York in North-America. Taken down from his own relation, arranged, corrected, and published by the Rev. Mr. Aldridge* (London, 1785) appears to have reached a seventh edition in 1790; see ESTC. Notably, none of these works overtly advocated for abolition of the slave trade, much less of slavery itself.

²⁷The Bibliothèque nationale de France (BnF) has one of the duodecimo and one of the octavo issues, pressmarks LK9-33(A) and LK9-33 respectively.

²⁸This strategy is not unlike that of the London Committee for the Abolition of the Slave trade, which in the same year (1788) printed the diagram of the slave ship *Brooks* (also known as the *Brookes*) in two versions: cheaper copies (7,000 in all) for public sale and distribution were printed from woodblock, while more expensive copies (1,700 in all), many given to Members of Parliament and other officials, were printed from copperplate. See minutes of the London Society for Effecting the Abolition of the Slave Trade, 1787–1819 BL Add. MS 21255, fol. 117^v, July 28, 1789.

²⁹[Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), 32: "il faudroit que la revolution fût l'effet de la volonté propre d'un Souverain, appuyée par l'opinion publique, ou de celle d'un corps législatif dont l'esprit fût constant."

The case for Condorcet as translator

Three forms of evidence—bibliographical, biographical, and textual—support the attribution of the translation to Condorcet. The main bibliographical evidence attesting to Condorcet's responsibility for the translation of Cugoano's work appears in the book catalogues of the work's printer–bookseller, Jean-François Royez, listing Condorcet as the translator, though only after the marquis's death in 1794.³⁰ A one-page Royez catalogue from 1796–7, for instance, lists “Réflexions sur l'esclavage et les nègres, trad. de Cuagano [sic], Africain, par Condorcet. 24 sols. Le même, beau papier, in-8°.”³¹ At the time *Réflexions* was published, Condorcet and Royez were working together on Condorcet's edition of the *Letters of M. Euler to a German Princess* (1787–8).³² Royez completed that mathematical project with the posthumous publication of Condorcet's related work, *Éléments du calcul des probabilités*, in 1804–5. At that time, he again advertised Condorcet's role in the Cugoano *Réflexions*.³³ It seems unlikely that Royez simply invented Condorcet's connection to the Cugoano project, for he repeated it in multiple catalogues and did so during the lifetime of Condorcet's widow, Sophie de Grouchy, who would have been in a position to object, had it been false.

In addition, a copy of the work in the University of Chicago Library has “par Condorcet” written in ink in an eighteenth-century hand on the title page.³⁴ If taken as independent pieces of evidence, the manuscript and publisher's attributions powerfully reinforce one another. It is possible, of course, that the basis for the attribution in the Chicago copy was a Royez advertisement; if this were the case, it would at least indicate that a contemporary reader found the attribution to Condorcet convincing and worthy of note.³⁵

³⁰ Royez advertised the book during Condorcet's lifetime without connecting it to the philosopher. See e.g. “Réflexions sur la traite & et l'Esclavage des Negres, in-18, 1 liv. 16 s,” in “Nouveautés qui se trouvent chez Royez, libraire, quai des Augustins, près le Pont-Neuf” [Paris: Royez, 1789], [page 3 of 4], at <https://catalogue.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb35947067d>.

³¹ Jean-François Royez, “Livres intéressants, sur-tout dans les circonstances, à vendres, à l'aimable, chez Royez, libraire, rue J.J. Rousseau, no. 345” (Paris: Royez, 1796–7), item 22 in Bernard Quaritch's catalogue, “New Acquisitions, September 2017,” at www.quaritch.com/wp-content/uploads/2017/09/Sep-17-New-Acquisitions.pdf.

³² See e.g. *Lettres de M. Euler à une princesse d'Allemagne sur différentes questions de physique et de philosophie*, nouvelle édition, avec des additions par MM. le M^{rs} de Condorcet et de La Croix (Paris, 1787–8); see <http://ark.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb339913488> and <http://ark.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb30409991v>. In 1804–5 Royez also published Condorcet's *Éléments du calcul des probabilités*, noting on the title page that the book was meant to appear soon after the *Letters of Euler* but was delayed by “the death of the Author and various circumstances.” Marie Jean Antoine Nicolas de Caritat, the Marquis de Condorcet, *Éléments du calcul des probabilités, et son application aux jeux de hasard, à la loterie, et aux jugemens des hommes, par feu M. de Condorcet, avec un discours sur les avantages des mathématiques sociales et une notice sur M. de Condorcet* (Paris, An-XIII—1805), at <http://ark.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb30263670h>.

³³ M. Royez, bookseller, also has works by Condorcet, together or separately, such as *Sur l'Esclavage des Nègres*, 1 vol., published under the name of Cuagano [sic], 2 l.” [Catalogue de libraire. Précédé d'un prospectus pour les “Éléments du calcul des probabilités ...”] (Paris: Royez, [1804–1805]); <http://ark.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb35947083n>

³⁴ For the University of Chicago catalog reference see <http://pi.lib.uchicago.edu/1001/cat/bib/3231079>.

³⁵ Could the fact that the title of the Cugoano translation—*Réflexions sur la traite et l'esclavage des Nègres*—is similar to the title of Condorcet's own 1781 work—*Réflexions sur l'esclavage des nègres*—have led a

Second, biographical hints in the translator's preface support our provisional attribution. The preface begins by stating that M "Piatoli," "who lived for a long time in London and who *particularly* knew Ottobah Cugoano," had sent the translator a note in Italian providing biographical background and testimony of Cugoano's character, his "excellent morals," and his piety.³⁶ Condorcet's personal connections to Scipione Piattoli (1749–1809) comport with the translator's invocation of this intermediary. The Florentine, a member of the Piarist order, came to know Condorcet in Paris in the late 1780s.³⁷ Notably, the translator's preface identifies Piattoli as the author of the Italian treatise *Saggio intorno al luogo del seppellire*, published in French translation in 1778 as *Essai sur les lieux et les dangers des sépultures*, a work on public health that Condorcet had reviewed admiringly in the *Mercure de France*.³⁸ One of Condorcet's correspondents later invoked Condorcet's esteem for Piattoli and his fellow Florentine Filippo Mazzei,³⁹ who were both foreign members of the Amis des noirs.⁴⁰

Piattoli, a foreigner in England as he was in France, thus came from outside the circle of the London Committee, the group of businessmen who in their campaign for abolition of the slave trade had kept their distance from Cugoano and his radical text. Piattoli knew Cugoano personally, perhaps through Richard and Maria Cosway, the London painters for whom Cugoano worked as a servant from at least 1784 until 1791.⁴¹ As Piattoli's note to the French translator attests, he held Cugoano in high regard

contemporary mistakenly to transfer the attribution of the latter to the former and inscribe "par Condorcet" on the title page? This is certainly possible, though it seems unlikely.

³⁶"Preface du Traducteur," Cugoano, *Réflexions sur la traite et l'esclavage des Nègres, Traduite de l'Anglais, d'OTTOBAH CUGOANO, afriquain, esclave à la Grenade et libre en Angleterre* (Paris, 1788), v–xii, at v–vi: "M. Piatoli, qui a vécu long-tems à Londres, et qui a particulièrement connu Ottobah Cugoano, m'a envoyé une note italienne, dont voici la traduction"; "ses moeurs sont excellent ... il est très-religieux."

³⁷Piattoli was in Paris from 1785 to 1787 as a tutor in the household of the Polish noble family Lubomirski. Emanuel Rostworowski, *Piattoli Scipione*, in *Polski Słownik Biograficzny*, vol. 25 (Zakład Narodowy Imienia Ossolińskich i Wydawnictwo Polskiej Akademii Nauk; Warsaw, 1980), 818–29.

³⁸The review of the translation, which appeared in the *Mercure de France* of 15 Nov. 1778, 158–66, was signed "Par M. L. M. D. C." This abbreviation of "Monsieur le Marquis de Condorcet" was one of Condorcet's occasional pseudonyms or bylines: see the entry on "Condorcet" in the *Dictionnaire des journalistes* (1600–1789), at <https://dictionnaire-journalistes.gazettes18e.fr/journaliste/190-jean-antoine-de-condorcet>. We are grateful to Gabriel Darriulat for these references.

³⁹Piattoli appears only once in Condorcet's correspondence, when he is referred to in a 1792 letter requesting a meeting from a man who introduces himself as a friend of "deux hommes que vous estimez [two men whom you esteem], MM. Mazzei et Piattoli." Marc Antoine Jullien à Condorcet, 4 [May 1792] (Paris, Bibliothèque de l'Institut de France / Ms 868, f. 111–12), at www.inventaire-condorcet.com/Inventaire/Correspondance?ID=402. Reprinted in Jean François Robinet, *Condorcet, sa vie, son oeuvre: 1743–1794* (Paris, 1893) 346–7.

⁴⁰Though not listed in the "Régistre," their names appear in a "Tableau des Membres de la Société des Amis des Noirs" (Paris, 1789), 22. The *tableau* can be found in a bound volume of texts on slavery published in 1789 in the Bibliothèque nationale, part of Moreau de Saint-Méry's collection, at <http://ark.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb45701778g>.

⁴¹Vincent Caretta, "Cuogano, Ottobah [John Stuart]," *Oxford DNB* (2004), at <https://doi.org/10.1093/ref:odnb/59531> (accessed 5 Aug. 2025). Maria Cosway (née Hadfield), like Piattoli, had come to London from Florence. Stephen Lloyd, "Cosway [née Hadfield], Maria Louisa," *Oxford DNB* (2004), at <https://doi.org/10.1093/ref:odnb/6382> (accessed 5 Aug. 2025).

for his “fidelity, exactitude, and intelligence.”⁴² It would make sense that, recognizing the book as an astonishing document, he chose to send it to his friend Condorcet—a conspicuous, published, and powerful advocate for the abolition of the slave trade—believing that Condorcet would find a sympathetic and compelling spirit in the words of Cugoano. Piattoli’s assurance in his letter to the future translator that the book had made the “greatest sensation in London” may indicate his willingness to stretch the truth in order to convey his own sense of the book’s importance, or it may be that in the Cosways’ circle the *Thoughts and Sentiments on the Evil of Slavery* had indeed made a splash and he was thus unaware of how modest its reception in London truly was.

The Piattoli–Condorcet association is deepened by the fact that in 1787–8 Condorcet and his wife, Sophie de Grouchy, were already collaborating with Piattoli’s close associate Mazzei on the publication of his *Recherches historiques et politiques sur les États-Unis de l’Amérique septentrionale ... par un citoyen de Virginie*, which contained Condorcet’s own *Lettres d’un Bourgeois de New-Heaven*, as well as an antislavery chapter consisting largely of an extract from the Schwartz *Réflexions*.⁴³ Mazzei recalled in his memoirs that Grouchy had undertaken to improve the translation of his Italian manuscript on America and had drawn her husband into the project.⁴⁴

It is plausible, then, that Condorcet and Grouchy might have been involved with another 1788 translation circulating among the same figures, all of whom were particularly invested at this moment in the antislavery cause. Grouchy would soon become an accomplished translator of works from English. Given her intellectual partnership with Condorcet, and the fact that 1788 was a tremendously busy year for him, it is worth considering the possibility that the two collaborated on the Cugoano translation. The translator’s preface refers to “L’écrit dont je publie la traduction” (“The writing whose translation I publish”), wording that leaves open the possibility that the author of the preface was not the sole translator of the work. Grouchy and Condorcet had married in 1786, and by 1788, thanks to Condorcet’s appointment as *inspecteur général des monnaies*, they were installed in the Hôtel des monnaies (incidentally near Royez’s bookstore), where Grouchy kept a salon frequented by American and British visitors, including Thomas Jefferson and Thomas Paine, whose work she would translate.⁴⁵ In

⁴²Cugoano, *Réflexions*, i.

⁴³[Filippo Mazzei], *Recherches historiques et politiques sur les États-Unis de l’Amérique septentrionale ... par un citoyen de Virginie ... Avec quatre Lettres d’un Bourgeois de New-Heaven sur l’unité de la législation* (À Colle et se trouve à Paris, chez Froullé, libraire, quai des Augustins, au coin de la rue Pavée, 1788). Colle was Mazzei’s estate in Virginia. On the relationship between Piattoli and Mazzei see Rostworowski, *Piattoli Scipione*, 818–29, at 819.

⁴⁴Mazzei, *Memorie della vita e delle peregrinazioni del fiorentino Filippo Mazzei*, vol. 1 (Lugano, 1845), 537–8. We are grateful to Kathleen McCrudden Illert for this reference and for her guidance regarding Grouchy; for discussion of the episode as well as the fullest account to date of Grouchy’s intellectual partnership with Condorcet see Kathleen McCrudden Illert, *A Republic of Sympathy: Sophie de Grouchy’s Politics and Philosophy, 1785–1815* (Cambridge, 2024).

⁴⁵Antoine Guillois, *La marquise de Condorcet, sa famille, son salon, ses amis 1764–1822* (Paris, 1897), 76–8. Also see Eliza Condorcet O’Connor, “Note biographique sur Mme de Condorcet,” in Jean-François Robinet, ed., *Condorcet: Sa vie, son oeuvre (1743–1794)* (Paris, 1893), 369–72. “It was Sophie who translated—that is who rethought in French—the appeal in favor of the Republic inspired by Condorcet, composed by Paine, signed Du Châtelet, printed by Bonneville and pasted to the walls of Paris on 1 July 1791.” See Frank Alengry, *Condorcet, guide de la Révolution française* (Paris, 1904), 93, quoted in Jean-Paul de Lagrave, “Sophie de

1790, she translated Adam Smith's *Theory of Moral Sentiments*, publishing it in 1798 together with her own *Letters on Sympathy*.⁴⁶

Grouchy was the first woman to join the Société des amis des noirs when Condorcet presented her for membership on 23 June 1789.⁴⁷ There is also evidence that she continued to work with Condorcet on matters concerning slavery and the volatile situation in the French colonies. As Kathleen McCrudden Illert has shown, annotations in Grouchy's hand suggest that she commented on a draft of Condorcet's (written in 1791 and published in 1792) that concerned a battle in the National Assembly between the proslavery lobby and the Amis des noirs over the decree of 15 May 1791 extending limited rights to free blacks in Saint-Domingue.⁴⁸ She also wrote to Brissot on Condorcet's behalf about that struggle, noting that Condorcet was sending the Amis des noirs a financial contribution, the "feeble tribute that his fortune permits him to offer at this moment, to liberty, humanity, and peace."⁴⁹ Publishing the Cugoano translation required a financial as well as an intellectual investment; Condorcet was evidently contributing funds to the Amis des noirs's activities and would likely have been in a position to subsidize the publication of Cugoano as well.

Third, there is suggestive textual evidence linking the Cugoano translation to Condorcet. The translator's preface calls attention to a series of abolitionist French authors: "the author of the notes on Pascal's *Pensées*," Saint-Lambert, Raynal, Garat, Saint-Pierre, and "especially M Schwartz."⁵⁰ Here Condorcet may be inserting himself into the translator's preface with a sly wink, not once but twice. He was not

Condorcet, *l'égérie du bonheur*, *Dix-huitième siècle* 36 (2004), 87–98. Also see Lagrave, "L'influence de Sophie de Grouchy sur la pensée de Condorcet," in Crépel and Gilain, *Condorcet: Mathématicien*, 434–42.

⁴⁶Karin Brown, *Sophie de Grouchy: Letters on Sympathy* (Philadelphia, 2008), xxv; Adam Smith, *Théorie des sentimens moraux ou Essai analytique sur les principes des jugemens que portent naturellement les hommes ... Huit lettres sur la sympathie* (par Mme de Condorcet), (Paris, an VI-1798).

⁴⁷"Régistre," 23 June 1789; Dorigny and Gainot, *La société des amis des noirs*, 233.

⁴⁸"Révision des travaux de la première législature," Paris, Bibliothèque de l'Institut de France, Ms 863, folios 181–205. In the version published in the *Chronique du mois* from January to June 1792, Condorcet added details as she had suggested; see McCrudden Illert, *Republic of Sympathy*, 78–9.

⁴⁹Grouchy to Brissot, 25 May 1791, Archives nationales, côte 446AP/7: "M. Condorcet dépose par vous entre les mains du trésorier de la Société des amis des noirs le faible tribut que sa fortune lui permet d'offrir en cet instant, à la liberté, à l'humanité, et à la paix. [signed] M.L.S. Grouchy Condorcet." We thank Kathleen McCrudden Illert for both references.

⁵⁰"Préface du traducteur," in Cugoano, *Réflexions*, v–xii, at vi–vii: "Mais je dois rappeler que l'auteur des notes sur les pensées de Pascal, M. de Saint-Lambert, dans le conte de Ziméo, M. l'abbé Raynal, dans son histoire philosophique, etc. M. Garat, dans une note du poème des Mois, M. le chevalier de saint-Pierre dans son voyage à l'Isle de France, et surtout M. Schwartz ont écrit avec beaucoup de force contre l'esclavage des Nègres." The authors and texts are as follows: Jean-François de Saint-Lambert, *Ziméo* (1769), at <http://ark.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb31282389d>; Guillaume-Thomas Raynal, *Histoire philosophique et politique des établissemens et du commerce des Européens dans les deux Indes* (1st edn 1774; subsequent editions with anonymous contributions by Diderot accentuated the critique of slavery); Joseph-Dominique Garat, who published a note arguing against slavery in Jean-Antoine Roucher, *Les Mois, poème en douze chants* (Paris, 1779), 127–36, at <https://gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/bpt6k1056843x/f146.item>; Henri Bernardin de Saint-Pierre, *Voyage à l'Île de France* (1773). Condorcet and Garat were close friends and associates. W. J. Murray, "A Philosophe in the French Revolution: Dominique-Joseph Garat and the *Journal de Paris*," in F. Krantz, ed., *History from Below: Studies in Popular Protest and Popular Ideology* (Oxford, 1988), 159–85. Condorcet had also singled out Saint-Pierre's *Voyage à l'Isle de France* in the Schwartz *Réflexions*, Ch. 8.

only M Schwartz, but also the author of the passionately abolitionist note in his 1776 edition of Pascal's *Pensées* discussed above.⁵¹ Both references remind us that some of Condorcet's own long-standing abolitionist beliefs were closely aligned with Cugoano's, as we delineate below.

Further, many of the names listed in the translator's preface also appear in a list of authors Condorcet included in his "Lettre à un marquis" (probably 1789), a response to a proslavery pamphlet by Pierre Victor Malouet.⁵² There, Condorcet, writing as M Schwartz to a marquis, likely Lafayette, responded to Malouet's insult that he suffered from an "inflammatory fever" with a list of authors with whom he said he shared a different *maladie*, the affliction of "philanthropy" (etymologically, the love of humankind): "Voltaire, l'abbé de Saint Pierre, Diderot, Rousseau, Helvetius, Saint-Lambert, [Bernardin] de Saint Pierre, l'abbé Raynal, Jefferson, Franklin, Smith, Garat, Dupont, &&&&, and even you, M le Marquis."⁵³ Condorcet's later list includes more authors, including some who were not consistently antislavery throughout their careers, but the appearance of all the names on the translator's list—and in largely the same order—is noteworthy. Other echoes of word choice also suggest affinities between the preoccupations of Condorcet's *Réflexions sur l'esclavage des Nègres* and those of the translator. Prefatory material in both books, for instance, represents these publications as works that combat the "insults" and "calumnies" against African slaves that the proslavery cause has been able to perpetrate.⁵⁴

Cugoano's book offered access to an extended argument in multiple registers: philosophical, scriptural, legal, economic, moral, and political. The translator repeatedly draws attention to the intellectual achievement that Cugoano's book represents, displaying his "piety and his knowledge" ("sa piété et ses connaissances"), and the "virtues and talents" ("des vertus et des talents") that formerly enslaved Blacks could cultivate if they were "free and educated" ("libres et instruits").⁵⁵ The varying levels on which

⁵¹The reference to the Pascal editor may also be meant to invoke Voltaire, who collaborated with Condorcet on a subsequent edition of the book, where the two engaged in an intricate dialogue in the notes that the book's modern editor calls a "jeu de miroirs." Richard Parrish, "Introduction," in Pascal, *Éloge et Pensées de Pascal*, 1–64, at 58.

⁵²We are grateful to Gabriel Darriulat for bringing to our attention the correspondence between these texts. Condorcet's two "Lettres à un marquis" were responses to Pierre Victor Malouet's *Mémoire sur l'esclavage des nègres* (1788). For discussion of this text see Gabriel Darriulat, "Universalisme des droits de l'homme et abolitionnisme chez Condorcet," conference presentation at Les libertés dans l'Europe des Lumières, Sorbonne Université, Paris, 18 Nov. 2023.

⁵³Bibliothèque de l'Institut de France, Paris, MS 857 f.302 verso and recto: "Mais peut-être ne se trompe-t-il que sur le nom de la maladie et que je suis un peu attaqué de celle qu'on a observé dans M. de Voltaire ... Dupont, et chez vous-mêmes M. le Marquis; mon médecin l'appelle en grec philanthropie et cette fièvre M. M. ne l'aura jamais." The "Lettre de M. de Condorcet à un Marquis" was published in Léon Cahen, "La Société des amis des noirs et Condorcet," *La Révolution française: Revue d'histoire modern et contemporaine* (1906), 498–504, where the list of names appears at 501.

⁵⁴Condorcet/Schwartz writes in his dedication to African slaves that the colonists claim "the right to insult you with calumnious libels" ("le droit de vous insulter dans des libelles calomnieux"); "Lettre dédicatoire," in [Condorcet], *Réflexions*, iii. The translator similarly complains of Europeans who "insult and calumniate Blacks without knowing them" ("insulter et calomnier les Nègres sans les connaître"). Cugoano, *Réflexions*, viii.

⁵⁵"Préface du traducteur," viii–ix.

Cugoano conducted his argument were ample proof against the prevailing idea of the intellectual incapacity of the native African fully to apprehend and apply the core truths upon which European civil society is based.

The translator even offers instances of critique to compare Cugoano favorably to Europeans. Conceding the author's occasional infelicities of style and errors of judgment, the translator takes care to mention European authors who have been similarly verbose or religiously dogmatic, concluding, "Perhaps it is not dishonorable for an African, without teacher or model, to reason better than men who read Demosthenes, Aristotle, Cicero, Tacitus, etc. etc."⁵⁶ In a note to the main text, the translator specifies his chief aim in publishing the translation as destroying "two prejudices: 1) the belief in the legitimacy of the slave trade [*traite des Nègres*]; 2) the charge of an incurable brutalization [*abrutissement*] that has been made against all Africans."⁵⁷

Both misapprehensions correspond closely to Condorcet's long-standing concerns. From his first recorded mention of enslaved Africans, in a 1773 letter to Benjamin Franklin, Condorcet had sought out evidence to dispel the claim that Africans were naturally inferior to Europeans.⁵⁸ And while in the Schwartz *Réflexions* Condorcet had written caustically that, "it cannot be denied that slaves have in general a great stupidity [*grande stupidité*]," he was stressing the profound injury that slavery inflicted on the capacities of the enslaved, thus insisting on their masters' culpability for their condition.⁵⁹ Despite such debasing effects of enslavement, Condorcet asserted that Africans are not only inherently equal to Europeans, but are shown to advantage by the comparison to white colonists.⁶⁰ The trope of favorable comparison prominent in the translator's preface is thus also consistent with Condorcet's long-established beliefs.

⁵⁶Ibid., xii: "Peut-être n'est-il pas déhonorant pour un Africain, sans maître et sans modèle, de raisonner mieux que des hommes qui lisaient cependant Démostène, Aristote, Cicéron, Tacite, etc. etc." "Préface du traducteur." See ibid., x, comparing Cugoano to the verbose Abbé de Saint-Pierre.

⁵⁷"Note du traducteur," in Cugoano, *Réflexions*, 89–90: "Comme mon but, en traduisant l'ouvrage de Cugoano, a été, et je l'ai déjà dit, d'essayer de détruire deux préjugés; 1° celui de la légitimité de la traite des Nègres; 2° celui d'un abrutissement incurable, don't a gratifié tous les Africains." *Abrutissement* entails having been reduced to the condition of a brute; see <https://dvlf.uchicago.edu/mot/abrutissement>.

⁵⁸Writing to Franklin as secretary of the Académie des sciences in 1773, Condorcet asked for information about the mind and character of free blacks in America. *Papers of Benjamin Franklin*, vol. 20, 490, at <https://franklinpapers.org/framedNames.jsp> (accessed 13 Nov. 2023), cited in Badinter and Badinter, *Condorcet*, 175.

⁵⁹Schwartz, *Réflexions*, Ch. 8. Similarly, Cugoano's translator writes, "African slaves have vices, yes, but their vices are the work of the slaveholders" ("Les Africains esclaves sont vicieux; oui: mais leurs vices sont l'ouvrage des colons"). Cugoano, *Réflexions*, ix.

⁶⁰[Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), i–ii: "Nature has formed you to have the same mind [*esprit*], the same reason, the same virtues as Whites; I speak here only of those of Europe, since as for the Whites of the Colonies, I do not do you the injustice of comparing them with you; I know how often your loyalty, your probity, your courage have made your masters blush. If one were seeking a man in the Islands of America, it would not be among people of white flesh that one would find him." See also Condorcet, "Remarques sur les Pensées de Pascal," in Condorcet, *Oeuvres*, 3: 635–52, at 650. "Set them free, and, closer than you to nature, they will be worth far more than you are" ("Rendez-les libres; et, plus près que vous de la nature, ils vaudront beaucoup mieux que vous").

One strand in the translator's preface that might be considered at odds with Condorcet's views is its appreciation for Cugoano's religious convictions. The translator admires Cugoano's piety, recommends the book to "all friends of humanity and of religion," and argues that its readers will learn that if blacks were free and educated, "they would bow their heads under the salutary yoke of a religion of peace, benevolence, charity and moderation."⁶¹ It might be thought that Condorcet, as a *philosophe* and an ally of Voltairean anticlericalism, would have found Cugoano's strongly scriptural argument entirely alien. The French version certainly trims some of the book's most elaborate scriptural arguments, especially Cugoano's extended refutation of the belief that the Bible marks Africans out for slavery, whether through God's mark on Cain (Genesis 4:1–16), or through Noah's curse of his son Ham and grandson Canaan (Genesis 9:20–27).⁶²

Yet Condorcet need not have agreed with all aspects of the work to consider it worthy of translation and publication, and even to highlight religious language showing that, properly understood, Europeans' own religious convictions proscribed slavery. Further, there is a precedent in his adoption of an evangelical voice in his own work in the persona of "M Schwartz," a "pastor of the holy Gospel."⁶³ As David Williams has observed, Pasteur Schwartz enabled Condorcet "to inject a slight note of protestant evangelicalism into his attack on slavery, a central feature of English abolitionism," though one less prominent in French debates of the time.⁶⁴

Thus, while we cannot yet definitively prove that Condorcet was the motive force behind this translation, we believe that the available evidence supports our provisional attribution to him. Further, Condorcet's own antislavery convictions both before and during the Revolution make it plausible and consequential that he might well have undertaken this translation and publication in 1788.

Intellectual affinities between Condorcet and Cugoano

Many of Cugoano's arguments accord strongly with the abolitionist positions that Condorcet had articulated in his writings before 1788. Principal among these shared convictions were seven core beliefs. Immediate emancipation was the only truly just policy.⁶⁵ Emancipation was economically viable and even advantageous for the nation.⁶⁶ Enslavement is an act of theft, one vastly graver than other forms of that crime.⁶⁷ Arguments presenting African slaves as prisoners of war captured in tribal battles are not credible: rather, the European traders were causing African wars in

⁶¹"Préface du traducteur," viii: "ils courberaient leur front sous le joug salutaire d'une religion de paix, de bienfaisance, de charité et de modération."

⁶²Compare e.g. Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, 30–34, with Cugoano, *Réflexions*, 52–6.

⁶³He is identified as "Pasteur du Saint-Evangile à Bienne; membre de la Société économique de B****."

⁶⁴Williams, *Condorcet and Modernity*, 144; Dockes makes a similar observation in "Condorcet et l'esclavage." Popkin has shown that religiously informed argument had a greater place in French revolutionary abolitionism than is generally recognized. Jeremy Popkin, "Religion and Antislavery in Revolutionary France and Saint-Domingue," *Slavery & Abolition* 46/1 (2025), 84–99.

⁶⁵[Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), Ch. 9, 33; Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, 91–2.

⁶⁶[Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), Ch. 6; Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, 100–1.

⁶⁷[Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), Ch. 1, 2; Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, 58–9.

order to generate a supply of slaves.⁶⁸ Because enslavement was a crime even when it was not recognized as such by the state, slaveholders had no property rights in those they purported to own, and no right to compensation if the state abolished slavery. On the contrary, it was the slaveholders who owed restitution to the emancipated slaves.⁶⁹ Finally, racial prejudice is essential to the operation and survival of such an obviously criminal system.⁷⁰ For all these arguments, Condorcet would have found corroboration of his own existing views in Cugoano's *Thoughts and Sentiments on the Evil of Slavery*.

Moreover, in his own *Réflexions*, Condorcet had given voice to his desire for intellectual connection with Africans in a dedicatory letter "aux Nègres esclaves," whom he addressed as his friends and brothers, lamenting the obstacles that prevented him from communicating with them.⁷¹ The translation's title page calls attention to Cugoano's authority as an "African, slave in Grenada and free in England," and the editorial apparatus often refers to "the African author," highlighting the novelty and significance of this authorial figure. Given what Condorcet had written about the enslavement of Africans over the previous decade and more, we may imagine that Cugoano's book would have struck him as the fulfilment of a great desire: that an African who had been enslaved, and then became fluent in the Christian religion and European law, would turn his education and experience to account by publishing a thoroughgoing refutation of slavery. The existence of Cugoano's volume gave the lie to two falsehoods that, according to Condorcet, fundamentally compromised the possibility of the brotherhood of humanity: that slavery is a legitimate commercial undertaking that does not taint the society as a whole, and that the non-European races are inferior and hence incapable of being fellow citizens and dependable trading partners.

In certain key respects, Cugoano's argument was far more radical than Condorcet's, above all in its insistence on the immediate abolition of slavery and its call for far-reaching projects of reparation by slaveholders and slaveholding nations. Like most British and French abolitionists at the time, Condorcet maintained that practical considerations made it necessary to abolish slavery gradually. Under the plan he proposed in the M Schwartz volume, slavery would not be completely abolished for seventy years.⁷² This cautious approach continued during the revolutionary period, when, like his associates in the Société des amis des noirs, he focused his efforts on the abolition of the slave trade, rather than of the institution of slavery itself.⁷³ Yet, by publishing

⁶⁸ [Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), Ch. 2, 5; cf. Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, 16, 26–7.

⁶⁹ Condorcet, "Remarques sur les Pensées de Pascal," 650; [Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), Chs. 7–8, 27–31; Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, 102.

⁷⁰ Condorcet, "Remarques sur les Pensées de Pascal," 647; Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, 22–3.

⁷¹ His letter "to Black slaves" reads in part, "I know that you will never know this Work, and that the sweetness of being blessed by you will always be denied me. But I will have satisfied my Heart, torn by the spectacle of your evils and aroused by the absurd insolence of your tyrants' sophisms" ("Je sais que vous ne connoîtrez jamais cet Ouvrage, & que la douceur d'être béni par vous me sera toujours refuse. Mais j'aurai satisfait mon Coeur déchiré par le spectacle de vos maux, soulevé par l'insolence absurde des sophismes de vos tyrans"). [Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), iii.

⁷² [Condorcet], *Réflexions* (1788), Ch. 9, 44.

⁷³ In an appeal to the French electorate that he drafted on behalf of the Amis des noirs in 1789, he wrote, "We know that there are injustices that one day cannot repair ... so we do not ask you to vote for the present destruction of these evils." ("Nous savons qu'il est des injustices qu'un jour ne peut réparer ... aussi nous ne

Cugoano's text, Condorcet would have been making available to the French public arguments in favor of immediate abolition, even if he was not prepared at the time to present them in his own name.

There are suggestions in the text that the translator did not shy from Cugoano's more provocative arguments, but even accentuated them. Cugoano, for instance, condemned revenge as unchristian, an inappropriate arrogation of God's power of punishment. But his arguments for the criminality of slavery and the duty of repentance and restitution led him to entertain a particularly explosive suggestion: that unrepentant former slaveholders could justly be held in enslavement by the community—put to work at tasks for the common benefit such as reclaiming waste land—in order to make some restitution to the injured and bring about their own reformation. Strikingly, it is this section that the French translation relegates to a footnote. The translator thus deftly brackets a contentious argument while also preserving it; indeed, the translator may be calling attention to the passage even while purporting to present it as a pericope of purely technical or historical interest.

Cugoano ended his book with a final prediction of the divine vengeance that would follow upon the nation's failure to repair the evils of slavery. Cugoano's English is ambiguous about what form that vengeance would take: he only hints at the possibility of retributive violence by the enslaved ("rend the mountains ... cleave in pieces the rocks ... smite the stoutest oaks in the forest").⁷⁴ In contrast, the French translation, with some small but significant changes to the final sentences, inserts an explicit prediction of a slave uprising: "the good-naturedness of the Blacks will become an indomitable fury that will overturn everything" ("la bonhomie des Noirs deviendra une fureur indomptable qui renversera tout").⁷⁵ The translator thus chooses to resolve the ambiguity of Cugoano's prophecy in the most militant direction the text allows. Far from holding Cugoano's book at arm's length, as the London abolition society had done, the French abolitionist responsible for this translation appears to be embracing, even intensifying, its radicalism.

Potential doubts and objections

Why has this translation not been attributed by scholars to Condorcet before now? Cugoano and his book are not, to our knowledge, mentioned in Condorcet's surviving papers and correspondence, nor is there any surviving direct correspondence with Piattoli. In the early nineteenth century, Antoine-Alexandre Barbier (1765–1825), then France's leading bibliographer and the state's chief librarian under the Directory and

vous demandons point de voter la destruction actuelle de ces maux.") "Au corps électoral, contre l'esclavage des Noirs," in Marie Jean Antoine Nicolas de Caritat, the Marquis de Condorcet, *Oeuvres de Condorcet*, vol. 9, ed. [E. O'Connor], F. Arago and A. O'Connor, (Paris, 1847), 469–75, at 472–3; compare Paris, Bibliothèque de l'Institut de France, MS 857, folios 279–84, at 280 recto.

⁷⁴The passage reads in full: "I must yet say, although it is not for me to determine the manner, that the voice of our complaint implies a vengeance, because of the great iniquity that you have done ... and if it is not hearkened unto, it may yet arise with a louder voice, as the rolling thunder, and it may increase in the force of its volubility, not only to shake the leaves of the most stout in heart, but to rend the mountains before them." Cugoano, *Thoughts and Sentiments*, 111.

⁷⁵Cugoano, *Réflexions*, 193–4.

the Consulate, attributed the translation to two different and unrelated translators, though without justification. Tellingly, Barbier makes these attributions in entries that misspell Cugoano's name or omit it altogether.⁷⁶ Yet scholars have accepted, without additional evidence, these attributions to either Antoine Diannyère (1762–1802) or Antoine-Gilbert Griffet de Labaume (1756–1805), even though neither was affiliated with the Amis des noirs.⁷⁷

The attribution of the translation to Diannyère appears for the first time in the second edition of Barbier (1824): “Cuyoano” is given as the author of this work.⁷⁸ Diannyère, a political economist and physician, was the author of the *Notice sur la vie et les ouvrages de Condorcet* (1795) and several works of political “arithmetic.”⁷⁹ It is not clear why Barbier attributed the translation of Cugoano's work to Diannyère. He ascribes to Diannyère no other translations of English works into French, nor have we located any. (Barbier elsewhere wrongly attributed to Diannyère a translation into English of Condorcet's “Déclaration des droits.”⁸⁰) Unlike Condorcet, who, as we have seen, was working with Royez in 1788, Diannyère published with other booksellers.⁸¹

All editions of Barbier's *Dictionnaire des ouvrages anonymes et pseudonymes*, beginning with the first in 1806, also include a listing for *Réflexions sur l'abolition de la traite et de l'esclavage des Nègres, traduites de l'anglais*, whose translation is attributed to Labaume; no 1788 work by this title exists, however, and it seems likely that this is an erroneous reference to the work by Cugoano.⁸² Labaume seems in some respects a more fitting candidate for the translator of Cugoano than Diannyère. Unlike Diannyère, he was an accomplished translator from English and he worked regularly with Royez.⁸³

⁷⁶ Antoine-Alexandre Barbier, *Dictionnaire des ouvrages anonymes et pseudonymes*, 3rd (posthumous) edn (Paris, 1872–79, reprinted 1963).

⁷⁷ See e.g. the facsimile edition of the *Réflexions* published in the series *La Révolution française et l'abolition de l'esclavage: Textes et documents*, vol. 10, *La Révolte des Noirs et des Créoles*, at <http://catalogue.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb37334117f>; the modern edition edited by Elsa Dorlin (Paris, 2009); and Gregory Pierrot, “Insights on ‘Lord Hoth’ and Ottobah Cugoano,” *Notes and Queries* 59/3 (2012), 367–9.

⁷⁸ “15823. *Réflexions sur la traite et l'esclavage des noirs: traduites de l'anglais d'Ottobah Cuyoano* [sic] (par Antoine Diannyère) Londres et Paris, Royez, 1788 in-8 et in-12,” in Antoine-Alexandre Barbier, *Dictionnaire des ouvrages anonymes et pseudonymes*, vol. 3 (Paris, 1824), 167.

⁷⁹ Antoine Diannyère, *Notice sur la vie et les ouvrages de Condorcet* (Paris, An IV). A facsimile of the second edition of 1798 was published in 2000. For other works see <http://cths.fr/an/savant.php?id=116184>.

⁸⁰ In a letter to Sophie de Grouchy, Barbier wrote that while he did not know why Condorcet had presented his “Déclaration des droits” as a translation from the English, perhaps it was to give it more weight “chez ses compatriotes.” He added that “Testimable Diyanère” then translated it into English, though Diannyère himself wrote in his *Notice sur la vie et les ouvrages de Condorcet* that he was not the work's translator but only the editor. See Jean-Nicolas Rieucau, “Quatorze lettres inédites de Sophie de Grouchy et des éditeurs des Oeuvres dites Complètes de Condorcet,” *Recherches sur Diderot et sur l'Encyclopédie* 39 (2005), para. 49, at <https://doi.org/10.4000/rde.322> (accessed 5 Aug. 2025).

⁸¹ P.-J. Duplin for his 1795 edition of the *Notice* and Debray and Bacot for the 1798 edition; C. C. Corancez and Roederer for his 1796 *Collection de divers ouvrages d'arithmétique politique*; Goujon fils for his 1799 *Essais d'arithmétique politique*.

⁸² “6084. *Réflexions sur l'abolition de la traite et de l'esclavage des Nègres, traduites de l'anglais* (par Labaume) 1788 in-8,” in Antoine-Alexandre Barbier, *Dictionnaire des ouvrages anonymes et pseudonymes*, vol. 2 (Paris, 1806), 275.

⁸³ Other translations attributed to him include Fanny Burney's *Evelina*, part of Laurence Sterne's *Tristram Shandy*, and Thomas Paine's *Common Sense*. Jean-Luc Chappey has defended the attribution to Labaume,

Yet Barbier himself gives reason both to doubt his attributions and to place some weight on the manuscript attribution of the translation to Condorcet in the University of Chicago's copy of *Réflexions*.⁸⁴ In his 1822 preface to his work's second edition, Barbier wrote that the first edition contained so many errors that he had been continually updating it since 1806, and that the second edition was less a revision than a new work altogether. He further observed that, of the two major sources for improved attributions, the first was manuscript notes found in individual copies of books: "nothing is more authentic than such articles: I pass up no occasion to procure them for myself, and they are to be met with very frequently in a city such as Paris, where book sales are so frequent."⁸⁵

Barbier also collaborated with Sophie de Grouchy on the twenty-one-volume *Oeuvres complètes de Condorcet* between 1801 and 1804.⁸⁶ Their work together on that edition could have put him in a position to learn from Grouchy of Condorcet's role in the Cugoano translation, so the fact that he did not attribute the translation to Condorcet represents a potentially significant gap in our evidence.⁸⁷ That said, it was not until after Grouchy's death in 1822 that Barbier listed Cugoano's work by name: as we noted above, the 1804 edition includes only a work with similar title but no author. Given the complexity of their work on the ambitious *Oeuvres complètes* of Condorcet, it is perhaps not surprising that this translation would not have arisen in their discussions of Condorcet's copious body of manuscripts.⁸⁸

Conclusion

A full history of Condorcet's abolitionist activities has yet to be written, and his possible engagement with the mind and writings of Quobna Ottobah Cugoano should figure in that history. Condorcet's participation in making this unprecedented and uniquely radical text available to the French public and political leadership represents the possibility of a hitherto unacknowledged intervention in the slave trade debate by a major figure who was one of the most active abolitionists in the country at that moment. Any future discussion of Condorcet and the Amis des noirs would benefit from taking this intervention into account.

Like Cugoano's English original, the French translation unfortunately seems to have enjoyed only limited circulation. The bookseller Jean-François Royez continued to advertise the work into the early years of the nineteenth century, suggesting that he

based on his association with Royez. Jean-Luc Chappey, "La traduction comme pratique politique chez Antoine-Gilbert Griffet de Labaume (1756–1805)," in Gilles Bertrand and Pierre Serna, eds., *La République en voyage (1770–1830)* (Rennes, 2013), 233–50; citing Madeleine Fabre, "Censeur universel anglais", in Jean Sgard, ed., *Dictionnaire des journaux 1600–1789* (Paris, 1991), notice 204, at <http://c18.net/dp/dp.php?no=204>.

⁸⁴ See <http://pi.lib.uchicago.edu/1001/cat/bib/3231079>.

⁸⁵ Antoine-Alexandre Barbier, *Dictionnaire des ouvrages anonymes et pseudonymes* (Paris, 1822), i–ii.

⁸⁶ The other main editors were Dominique Joseph Garat and Pierre Jean Georges Cabanis, and still others were involved more peripherally. See Rieucan, "Quatorze lettres inédites."

⁸⁷ Thanks to Jean-Nicolas Rieucan for raising this objection.

⁸⁸ Rieucan, "Quatorze lettres inédites," ¶13, for instance, notes that Grouchy regretted that many texts had been left out of the 1801–4 *Oeuvres complètes*.

or the book's patron had anticipated far greater sales than the *Réflexions* actually had in 1788 and that a number of copies were available for sale as late as 1805.⁸⁹ We know that the prominent Saint-Domingue *colon* Moreau de Saint-Méry, one of the leaders of the proslavery lobby the Club Massiac, had a copy in his library.⁹⁰ And the abolitionist Abbé Grégoire wrote about Cugoano in his 1808 book *De la littérature des nègres*, where he stressed Cugoano's belief that divine punishment would be visited on the nation for the crime of slavery.⁹¹ But beyond these instances, there is little evidence of the circulation or readership of Cugoano's book in France. Remarkably few copies remain: in addition to Moreau's copy in the national archives, the Bibliothèque nationale holds two, including the copy from the Bibliothèque royale, and libraries at Avignon and Blois each hold a single copy. In March 2024, the Parisian antiquarian bookseller Rodolphe Chamonal advertised a large (octavo) copy for sale, describing it as "très rare."⁹² Copies in the US include those in the New York Public Library's Schomburg Center for Research in Black Culture, at the University of Chicago, and at Howard University. We have identified only a single copy in the UK, held by the Museum of London.⁹³

Why did the *Réflexions sur la traite et l'esclavage des Nègres* not secure widespread popular appeal in France? The reasons for the book's failure to circulate widely appear to have been very different from the causes of the publishing fiasco of the *Thoughts and Sentiments* in England. Whereas it seems the book's radicalism led the London abolition society to ignore it altogether, French abolitionists were apparently prepared to champion the book. Someone clearly made a serious investment in its translation and publication. And, as we mentioned earlier, in May 1790 the Société des amis des noirs listed the translation in Brissot's journal *Le patriote français* among noteworthy abolitionist works in their collection available for consultation ("existent aux archives de la société des Amis des Noirs, et peuvent y être consultés").⁹⁴

⁸⁹ *Catalogue de librairie. Précédé d'un prospectus pour les "Elémens du calcul des probabilités ..."* (Paris, [1804–5]), at <http://ark.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb35947083n>. Page 2 of this catalogue lists "Sur l'Esclavage des Nègres, 1 vol., publié sous le nom de Cuagano [*sic*], 2 l."

⁹⁰ This copy, in a *Sammelband* of works on slavery, is held by the Archives nationales d'outre-mer (ANOM). See <http://catalogue.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cb455450571>.

⁹¹ Grégoire also misread the text in a way that led to long-standing confusion about Cugoano's biography, mistaking a reference to God as Lord of Hosts for a reference to a nonexistent English Lord Hoth. "A slave in Grenada, he owed his liberty to the generosity of Lord Hoth, who brought him to England" ("Esclave à la Grenade, il dû sa liberté à la générosité du lord Hoth, qui l'amena en Angleterre). Henri Grégoire, *De la littérature des nègres: Recherches sur leurs facultés intellectuelles, leurs qualités morales et leur littérature; suivies de notices sur la vie et les ouvrages des nègres qui se sont distingués dans les sciences, les lettres et les arts* (Paris, 1808), 215; see also Pierrot, "Insights on 'Lord Hoth' and Ottobah Cugoano," 367–8.

⁹² Librairie Rodolphe Chamonal, List of "Antiquarian Books" for sale at the New York International Antiquarian Book Fair, item 100 (Réf. 37907), 4–7 April 2024, PDF circulated via email, 18 March 2024.

⁹³ We thank Lluís Tembleque Teres of the Museum of London for communications regarding this copy. Britain's unified catalog, Library Hub Discover, suggests that there is no other known copy in the UK: <https://discover.libraryhub.jisc.ac.uk/search?q=Cugoano%20Réflexions%201788&rn=2>. We are continuing to search for copies in both public and private collections in the US and Europe.

⁹⁴ *Le patriote français*, 7 May 1790, 8.

The profound disruption to public and private life occasioned by the Revolution and its aftermath may have been a contributing factor to slow sales of the *Réflexions*. The Société des amis des noirs's ambitious project of publishing translations of English abolitionist works, which lay at the center of its agenda from its first meeting on 19 February 1788, was quickly eclipsed by political upheaval. Less than three months after its founding, the society voted to delay its publishing program: given the political impasse between the king and the Paris Parlement, "current circumstances absorbing all the public attention, in publishing translations of English works on the slave trade, we would risk not being read."⁹⁵

The very different fate in England and France of another Afro-British author's book helps us to understand the implications of the society's aborted publishing program and the reading public's shifting attention away from abolitionist works. *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano*, by Cugoana's friend and fellow leader of the abolitionist group the Sons of Africa, was published in London in 1789. In England, Equiano's book, with its more conciliatory tone and gradualist approach to abolition, was embraced by the London Committee, supported by extensive subscriptions, and frequently republished. It went into nine English editions before Equiano's death in 1797 and was translated into Dutch (1790), German (1792), and Russian (1794).⁹⁶ But Equiano's book was published after the progress of the Revolution had interrupted the translation activities of the society, and it was not translated into French in the eighteenth century; indeed, no French edition was printed for nearly two hundred years.⁹⁷

The courses of abolition in France and Britain were also very different. The British abolitionists, earlier to organize, had a much more robust network of supporters, with antislavery societies in all the major cities, a vast project to gather evidence of slavery's manifold abuses, and a powerfully orchestrated program to publish and distribute books and pamphlets denouncing slavery and the slave trade. Nonetheless, Britain first abolished the trade only in 1807, and slavery in 1833.⁹⁸ Slavery was initially abolished much earlier in the French Empire, on 4 February 1794, by the decree of 16 pluviôse, an II. The Convention's vote to abolish slavery was not due to the simple triumph of republican or humanitarian argument, however. Rather, the pressure of slave uprisings in Saint-Domingue had led France's commissioners in the

⁹⁵"Régistre," 6 May 1788: "les circonstances actuelles absorbant toute l'attention publique, on risquerait, en publiant les traductions des ouvrages anglais concernant la traite et l'esclavage des Nègres, de ne pas être lu." Dorigny and Gainot, *La société des amis des noirs*, 163. Cf. Geggus, "Racial Equality, Slavery, and Colonial Secession."

⁹⁶Christopher Fyfe, 'Paul Edwards: A Tribute', *Slavery and Abolition* 19/3 (1998), 134–9; "Editions of *The Interesting Narrative*," *Equiano's World*, at <https://equianosworld.org/publications.php>.

⁹⁷*La veridique histoire par lui meme d'Olaudah Equiano, Africain, esclave aux Caraïbes, homme libre*. Introduction abrégée de Paul Edwards; avant-propos de Erika M'Bokolo; traduit de l'anglais par Claire-Lise Charbonnier (Paris, 1987).

⁹⁸The Slavery Abolition Act 1833 (3 & 4 Will. 4. c. 73) came into force on 1 August 1834. The first "apprenticeships" of the formerly enslaved came to an end in August 1838; the final apprenticeships were scheduled to end in August 1840.

colony, Léger-Félicité Sonthonax and Étienne Polverel, to order the abolition of slavery in a series of decrees in the summer of 1793.⁹⁹ This decision was belatedly ratified by the Convention's February 1794 vote, a decision that Popkin has described as "impulsive."¹⁰⁰

Yet the translation of Cugoano's book stands as compelling evidence of something further that is important for understanding the course of abolition in France: the coexistence of multiple temporalities of abolition, of arguments for what was morally necessary—immediate emancipation—alongside plans for what was politically possible—abolition by stages. Even if their main agenda was a pragmatic program of gradualism, the French abolitionists showed themselves to be less reluctant than their British models to sponsor a radical call for immediate emancipation.¹⁰¹ And they seized the opportunity for the immediate abolition of slavery when it presented itself.

The first French abolition was the product of a combination of rebellion by the enslaved and the action of elites. Because the French abolitionist movement was less deeply rooted in society than the British campaign, however, the decision was also less stable, and Napoleon did not encounter any generalized resistance when he reinstated slavery in 1802.¹⁰² In Britain, the evolution of abolition was slower but more solidly anchored in the general populace. France's elite antislavery lobby bore little resemblance to the extensive, regionally dispersed movement in Britain, and even less to the vast national project of repentance and restitution envisioned by Cugoano. For Cugoano's program of immediate abolition was only one facet of his strategy for a morally appropriate response to European society's complicity in slavery. He believed that the work of reparation and restitution would require engagement of the whole society over a long period. As the lone black voice in French abolitionist debates, Cugoano's *Réflexions* offered a profound vision of the multigenerational work requisite for confronting the legacies of slavery. It should be remembered as part of the intellectual history of the French Enlightenment.

⁹⁹ On 21 June 1793 they declared the emancipation of those willing to fight for the republic; then extended the decree to wives and children of soldiers, and finally declared general emancipations of all territories under French control. See Jeremy Popkin, *"You Are All Free": The Haitian Revolution and the Abolition of Slavery* (Cambridge, 2010); Susan Peabody, "France's Two Emancipations in Comparative Context," in Hideaki Suzuki, ed., *Abolitions as a Global Experiment* (Singapore, 2015), 25–49, at 28.

¹⁰⁰ Jeremy Popkin, "Declarations of Rights," in Dan Edelstein and Jennifer Pitts, eds., *Cambridge History of Rights*, vol. 4, *The Eighteenth and Nineteenth Centuries* (Cambridge, 2025), 200–27, at 221; also see Pierre Serna, "Que s'est-il dit à la Convention les 15, 16 et 17 pluviôse an II? Ou lorsque la naissance de la citoyenneté universelle provoque l'invention du 'crime de lèse-humanité,'" *La Révolution française: Cahiers de l'Institut d'histoire de la Révolution française* 7 (2014), at <https://journals.openedition.org/Irf/1208> (accessed 5 Aug. 2025).

¹⁰¹ Yves Bénéot, *La Révolution française et la fin des colonies* (Paris, 1988), 7–9.

¹⁰² Yves Bénéot, *La démente colonial sous Napoléon* (Paris, 1992); Bernard Gainot, "Métropole/colonies: Projets constitutionnels et rapports de force. 1798–1802," in Yves Bénéot and Marcel Dorigny, eds., *1802: Rétablissement de l'esclavage dans les colonies françaises* (Paris, 2003), 2–16; Lawrence C. Jennings, "La lente renaissance du mouvement abolitionniste en France," in *ibid.*, 365–74; Pierre Branda and Thierry Lentz, "Napoleon, Slavery, and the Colonies," *Napoleonica the Journal* 1/1 (2022), 7–145.

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